

F. The settlement by Periods

A difficulty here is rooted in the difference in comparisons: in the Ephraim survey (Finkelstein and Lederman 1997) the work conducted in the fringes of the desert was very partial, and the same is true for the survey of Benjamin (Magen and Finkelstein 1993). The survey of Judah was not published. Comparison to the Beth Shean and Jezreel Valley survey (Zory 1962;

1977) is also difficult because of the differences in technique and intensity of the work. A more relevant comparison is with the Mediterranean region of Manasseh (Zertal 2004).

The division into archaeological periods is based upon the chart in the 1975 edition of the *Encyclopaedia of Excavations* (Avi Yonah and Stern 1975). This chart is brought here with slight variations:

Period	Years	
Chalcolithic Period ca.	4500-3150	BCE
Early Bronze Age IA-C	3150-2850	"
Early Bronze Age II	2850-2650	"
Early Bronze Age III	2650-2350	"
Early Bronze Age IV	2350-2200	"
Middle Bronze Age I (IEB-MBA)	2200-2000	"
Middle Bronze Age IIA	2000-1750	"
Middle Bronze Age IIB	1750-1550	"
Late Bronze Age I	1500-1400	"
Late Bronze Age IIA	1400-1300	"
Late Bronze Age IIB	1300-1200	"
Iron Age IA	1200-1100	"
Iron Age IB	1100-1000	"
Iron Age II	1000-721	"
Iron Age III	721-586	"
Babylonian and Persian Period	586-332	"
Hellenistic Period	332-62	"
Early Roman Period	62 BCE –	73 CE
Late Roman Period	73-313	CE
Byzantine Period	313-632	"
Early Moslem	632-1099	"
Middle Ages	1099-1534	"
Ottoman Period	1534-1917	"
Modern	1917 on	"

Table 2. Chronological table of Archaeological Periods.

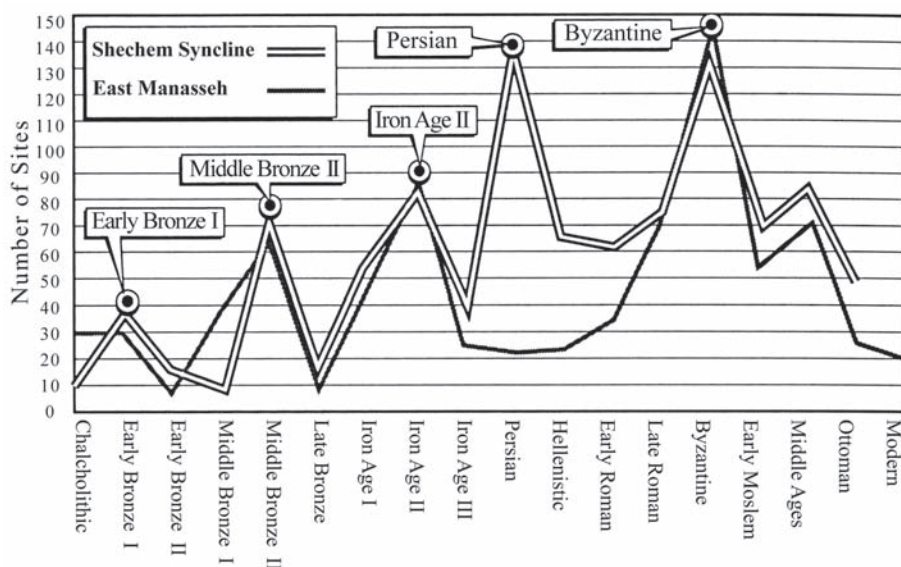
1. Chalcolithic Period

The 31 sites with Chalcolithic Period pottery are more than twice as many as those found in the Shechem Syncline (cf. Vol. I, Zertal 2004, 40-41). The area of the latter is only 25% smaller than the present volume, a fact indicating a clear preference of the Chalcolithic Period population for arid and semi-desert conditions. This is proven as well by the prosperity of the cultures in Beersheba, Ghassul and the Jordan Valley (Zertal 2005, 56-58).

The Chalcolithic Period sites are concentrated in groups: eight are located at the Zebabdeh Valley and Ras es-Salmeh, above all along Wadi Shubash. This group con-

tinues into the Beth Shean Valley group, with a possible relationship between the two. Another group (eight sites) is situated along Wadi Far'ah, and both groups create half of the overall number in the period. In each of the other units one or two sites were registered, and the inner regions, Wadi Malih, Ras Jadir, the Buqe'ah and the Desert Fringes, are very sparsely settled. We assume that the reasons for this special pattern relate, above all, to human factors – organization by tribes or families.

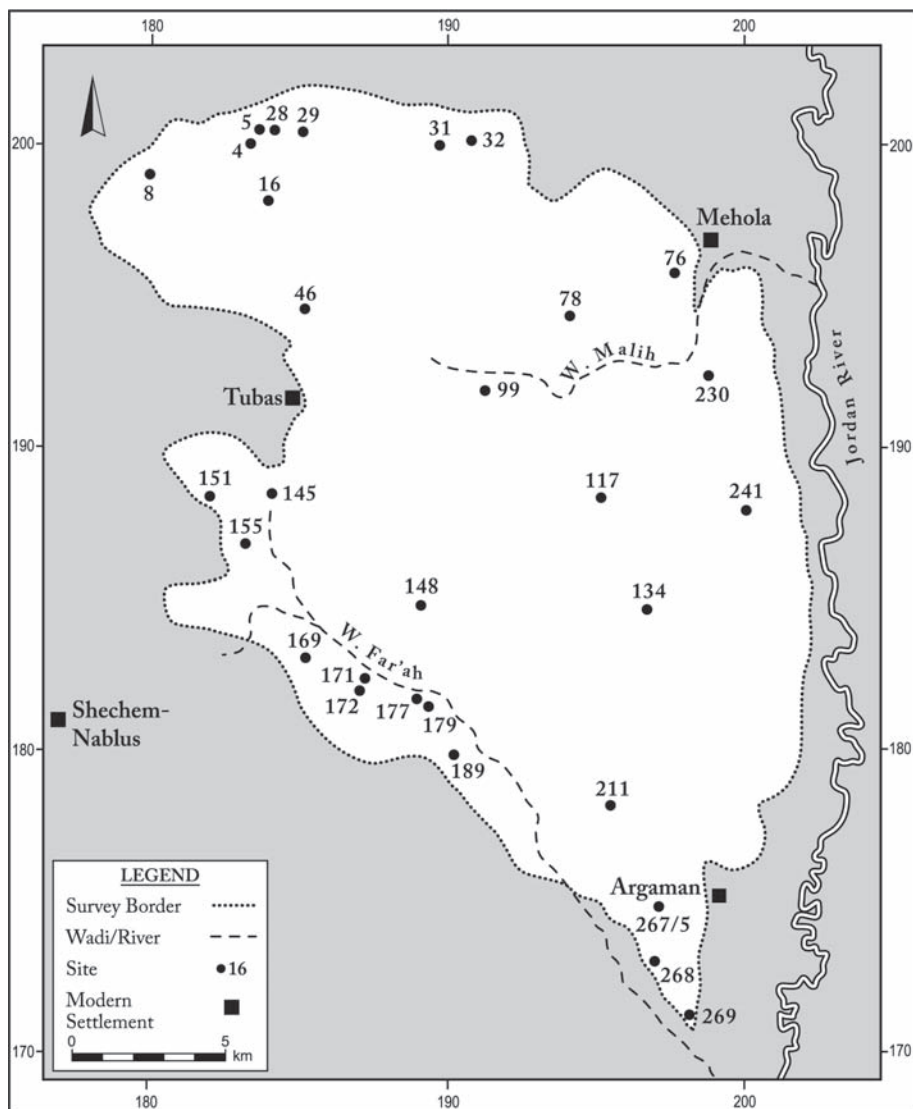
A computerized analysis of the connection to natural elements showed dependency on water: the locations of the Wadi Shubash group suggests that a perennial stream in the wadi must have exist-



22. The number of sites in the Shechem Syncline compared to East Manasseh.

ed during the period which is now dry. This model is supported by the dry springs with travertine found in East Manasseh, which bore water in the past (Zertal 1988, 183-184), together with the crowded sites along Wadi Far'ah and in the Jordan Valley. Those sites in the in-

ternal regions may have been temporary encampments. Soil seems not to have played a role, because of the wide areas of pasture around. The Mediterranean evergreen forest was of low priority, and only few Chalcolithic Period sites penetrated into it.



23. Map of the Chalcolithic Period sites.

The typical Chalcolithic Period site is small, 1-2 dunams of area on the average. About half of the sites contain preserved architecture and the others are concentrations of flint items and potsherds. Those of the first group contain primarily round or oval enclosures, with a few sites with scattered houses. The second group typically has dense concentration of items, like Muḡhur Abu Rishy in the Zebabdeh Valley (no. 16).

An additional division is between adze bearing places and the others. Many flint adzes were found along Wadi Shubash, the “northern” (Beth Shean) group and in the valleys of Zebabdeh and Tubas. In the inner regions and Wadi Far’ah, on the other hand, only a few adzes were detected. If the adze was used for cultivation, as argued by some scholars, then cultivation was concentrated in these territories, while others were above all used for pasture.

The enclosure walls are built of relatively large rocks, with few building remains outside. In these settlements potsherds are limited in number and no adzes were found. The similar enclosures in the Jordan Valley near Masu’ah (*cf.* vol. IV, Zertal 2005, sites 80, 89, 91, etc.) suggest temporary pastoral settlements.

Architectural sites with adzes do occur in several areas. One of these, ‘Ain Hilu (site 229), is being exca-

vated under the direction of S. Bar. There, a well-planned village is being unearthed, with buildings, a wealth of pottery and at least four stratigraphical stages.

Comparisons to regions neighboring to the area of vol. II are few. In the Beth Shean Valley, Zori (1962, 298) found 29 sites with Chalcolithic Period “presence”, mostly within tells. In Ramat Issachar, especially suitable for grazing, Gal (1980) found only three Chalcolithic Period sites. This scarcity is explained by Gal (*idem*, 64-65) through the ecology of the basalt plateaus. South of Manasseh, in the Mediterranean area of Ephraim, no Chalcolithic Period sites are mentioned, nor in Benjamin (Goldfuss and Golani 1993, 278.)

2. *Early Bronze Age I (= EBA I)*

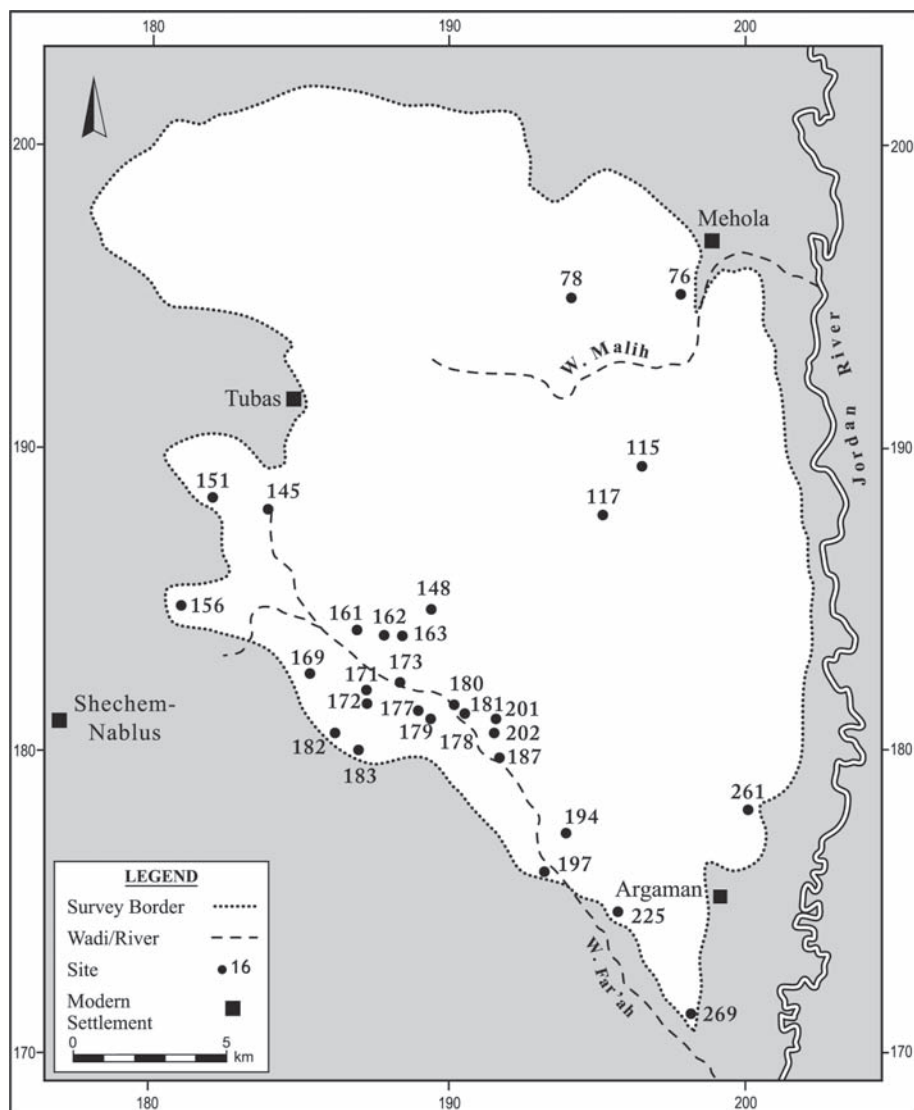
The nearly 300 years of this period indicate a settlement “boom” in the Mediterranean region, while East Manasseh remains stable. The Early Bronze Age culture is basically Mediterranean, based on orchard cultivation and much dependent upon water sources (Zertal 1993a).

Potsherds of this period are registered in 29 sites. Their definition depends on the “grain wash” slip of pottery, the “red painted” family, etc. Nineteen sites, 65 percent of the total, are situated in the valley of Wadi Far’ah, which is only 18% of the total area.

Twelve of the sites, also concentrated in Wadi Far'ah, show continuity from the Chalcolithic Period. However, the material culture of the two differ greatly. In comparison, the 37 Early Bronze Age I sites in the Shechem Syncline are 20% more than in the territory dis-

cussed, and the existence of only few of the latter continue from the Chalcolithic Period.

Most of the Early Bronze Age I sites in Wadi Far'ah are grouped in its western part, around the springs of the northern cliffs of Jebel Kebir. Two other sites surround Tel el-



24. Map of the Early Bronze Age I sites.

Far'ah (no. 151) and several others, without architecture, are scattered along Wadi Fau, between Ras Jadir and the Desert Fringes. This last phenomenon is difficult to explain, unless there may have been a perennial water flow in the wadi during the 3rd millennium BCE.

The excavations in Transjordan by Helms (1992) and others has clearly shown that the "Far'ah family" belong to the Early Bronze Age I horizon. Connection to perennial water is crucial in Early Bronze Age I – 95% of the sites are within the circle of 200 m from a water-source. On the other hand, no sites were registered along perennial Wadi Malih, except the small tell el-Hilu (no. 96).

Two of the sites, those of Abu Loz and el-Khelaiyel (nos. 145 and 148 respectively) presumably served for cult. Three others (nos. 161-163) are cemeteries in the Wadi Far'ah Valley. The impressive site of Jellamet Ahmar (A – no. 178) was used for burial as well, and Wadi Far'ah in general undoubtedly served as a central burial ground of the period, of the model already known from Bab edh-Dhra' in Transjordan.

Again in Wadi Far'ah, a group of pottery vessels ("the Far'ah family") typifies the region. These are large bowls and basins with widened rims, shelf rims in many cases, and many rope decorations. There are also ledge handles together with loop handles. Most of the vessels

are light brown in color. De Vaux (1947, fig. 5: 1-18) isolated them in Tel el Far'ah and named them *en-eolithique superieure*. For analysis cf. chapter Two, paragraph D.

Most of the Early Bronze Age I sites are small and unfortified. 'Ain Farr, for example (no. 169) is a concentration of shards on a moderate slope beside a spring ('Ain Farr). Others are at the bottom of tells, covered by the many upper layers. The Early Bronze Age I is the basis to many Early Bronze Age II-III tells. However, only few of these tells have developed and are known in East Manasseh. We assume that most of the East Manasseh Early Bronze Age sites were but an offshoot of the large Mediterranean cities.

Comparison to the other neighboring areas is difficult. In the Beth Shean Valley, Zori (1962, 197) refers to 45 sites of the "early Canaanite period", with no inner division. Gal (1980, 67-68) divides the period into "gray burnished" and "grain wash" pottery families. He argues that "Following the abandonment of the large Chalcolithic Period settlements in the [Beth Shean] valley, a small and different system of Early Bronze Age I sites, much lower in number and intensity, replaced them [in Issachar highlands]" (*idem*, 67). Yet our finds indicate two different periods of Chalcolithic and Early Bronze Age, and comparison is hard or impos-

sible.

Unlike Manasseh, in Ephraim no “settlement wave” was recorded, and the existing sites are not divided into stages.

3. *Early Bronze Age II–III* (= *EBA II–III, the* *“Urbanization Period”*)

This period is a time of change and decline by number of sites, together with a concentration of the population into fortified cities (Kempinski 1983). In only eight of the total number of sites in the present volume, pottery of that period was found. Four of them are large tells (Tel el-Far‘ah, er-Rjjum [no. 187], Tel Za‘anuni [no. 183] and el-Makhruq [no. 269]). All these are situated upon high, isolated ridges. The fifth is a small one (Tel Shibley – no. 180).

This decrease in number, with just one third out of the preceding Early Bronze Age I sites remaining, is quite significant. It indicates the abandonment of the semi-arid regions and the concentration in the Mediterranean ones (though in the latter also there is a decline). In this period, the nine most important cities in the Shechem Syncline are founded: the tells Muhaffar, Dathan, Beth Haggan, Yibleam, Kh. Najjar, Umm el-Hawa, el-Hawarah, es-Sunkur and es-Sirtassah.

Two of the tells of East Manasseh have been excavated: Tel el-Far‘ah

and el-Makhruq. Both show an impressive, developed fortification system and urban planning (De Vaux 1992, 1298-1299; Miroscchdji 1993, 434-437; Yeivin 1993). The fortification of er-Rjjum is quite sophisticated: it is disconnected from the ridge by a moat (?) and fortified by two city walls, a gate system and towers. The city of Za‘anuni is strategically situated, with wide city wall surrounding the lower city.

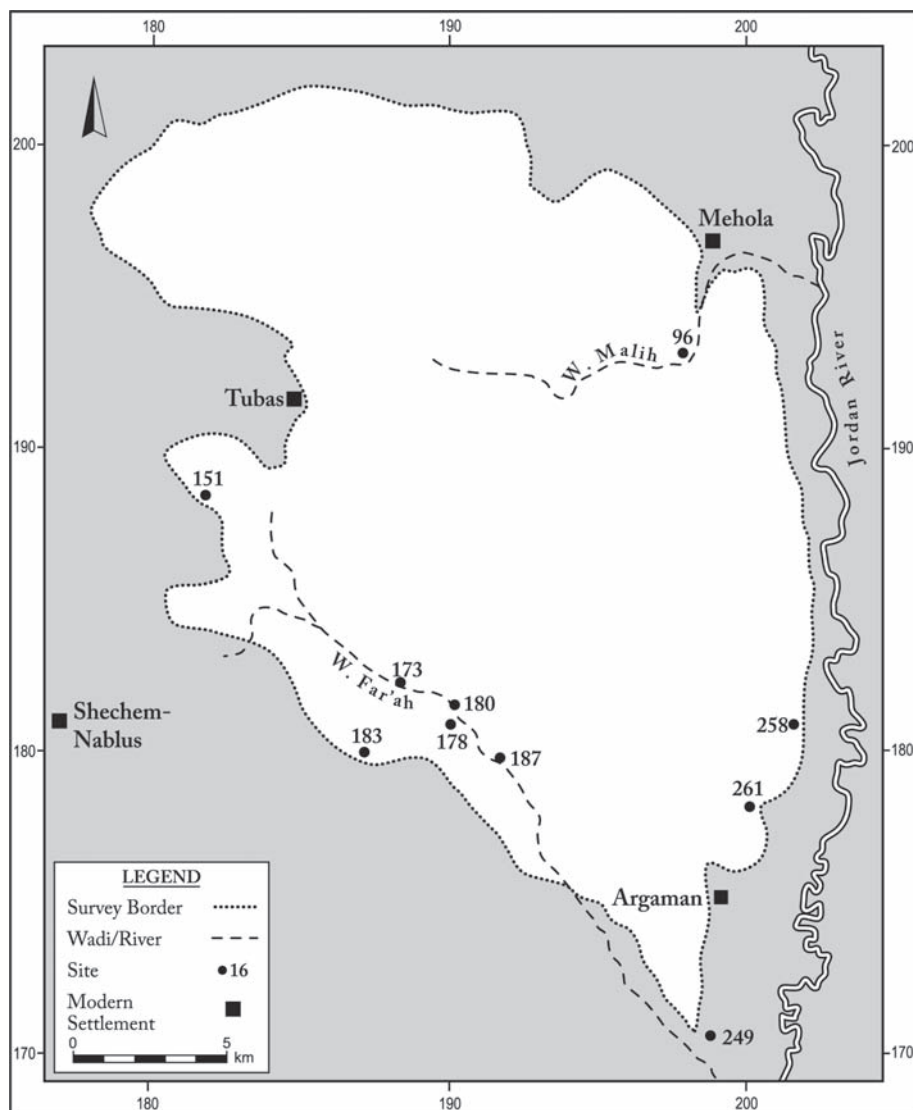
Both the decrease in number of sites and the developed fortification suits the “external threats” theory (*cf.* Kempinski 1983). Roads and water are both important elements in site location choice: the five tells of Early Bronze Age II–III are all situated along the road of Wadi Far‘ah. It may be assumed that the Far‘ah group was related to the “Early Bronze Age entity” (chiefdom or kingdom) east of the Jordan River (Melaart 1962; Ibrahim, Sauer and Yassine 1976; Ibrahim 1992). It can be concluded as well that Wadi Far‘ah – with its tells, road, water supply and cemeteries – seems as the most important Early Bronze Age center in East Manasseh, in some aspects similar to Bab edh-Dhra‘ on the other side of the Jordan River.

Gal (1980, 69-70) indicates that new prosperity begins already in the second stage of Early Bronze Age I. He argues that the passage into Early Bronze Age II was “a process without crisis” (*idem*). However, in

Manasseh this passage seems much sharper in character, and the decline continues in Early Bronze Age III. In Ephraim and Benjamin there is indication of several fortified tells near the national watershed (Finckelstein 1988-1989, 137), including the large tell of the 'Ai (et-Tell).

4. Middle Bronze Age I (= MBA I, Kenyon's "EBA-MBA Intermediate Period").

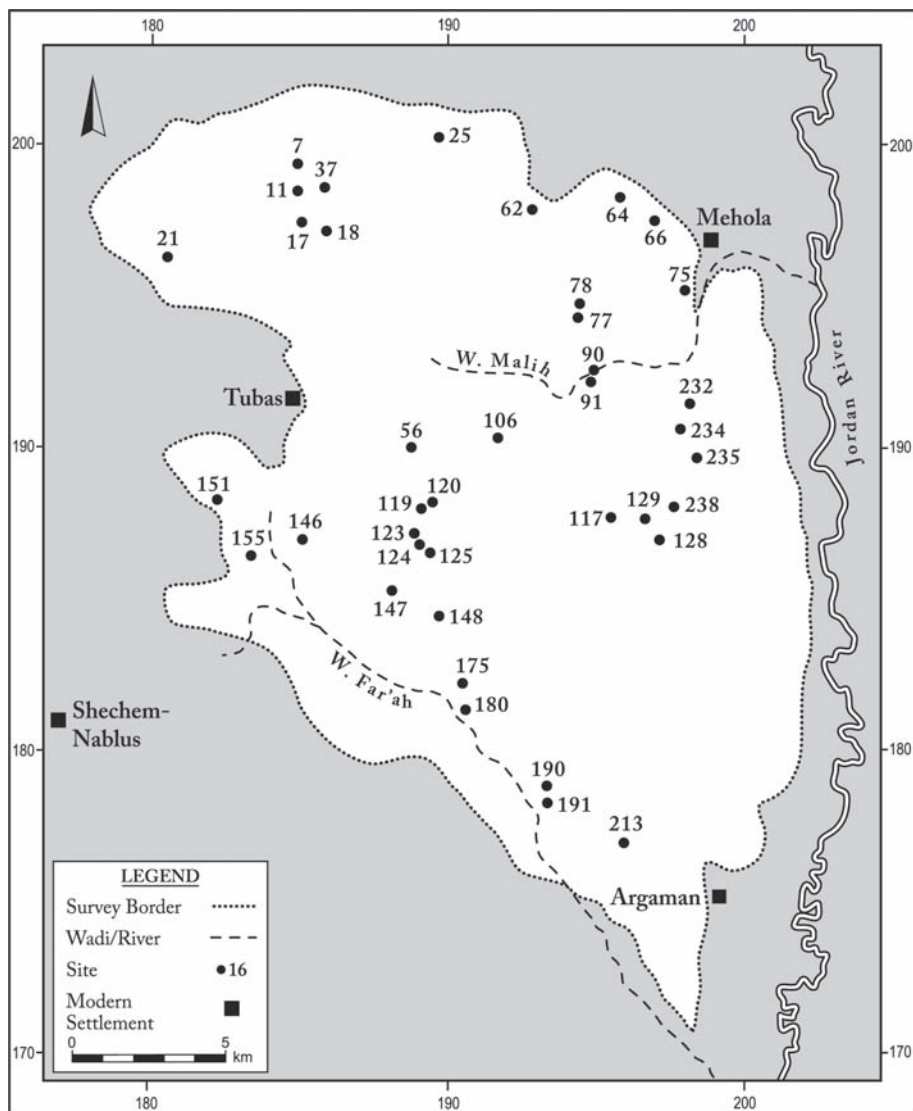
Following the decline of the Early Bronze Age culture the next period, Middle Bronze Age I, saw the foundation of a different society. Only



25. Map of the Early Bronze Age II-III sites.

five of the 39 Middle Bronze Age I sites are founded upon earlier sites; 34 of the sites, or 87% of the total, are newly founded on virgin soil. It is obvious, therefore, that the Middle Bronze Age I populace was motivated by new ecological and social considerations.

The number of sites is one third more than in Chalcolithic Period and Early Bronze Age I, and 80% more than in Early Bronze Age II-III. The new society seems better suited to the conditions of an arid region. In Mediterranean Manasseh, equal in area, there are



26. Map of the Middle Bronze Age I sites.

only nine settlements of the period (Zertal 2004, 46).

The Middle Bronze Age I sites are grouped or clustered together. The main groups are as follows:

1. Five settlements in the eastern Dothan Valley;
2. Five sites in the northern Zebabdeh Valley;
3. In the area of Bardaleh – the biggest cluster, part of which appears in vol. IV (Zertal 2005, 37-42).
4. Six sites in west Buqei'ah, near Tammun;
5. Six along Wadi Fau, from Peles to Wadi Malih;
6. Five in western Wadi Far'ah, three of which are cemeteries;
7. Two large sites in Wadi Malih.

Within these clusters, distances between individual sites are small (500 to 1000 meters), and it seems that each group functioned together. Between the clusters are large empty areas, which might have been used for grazing.

As seen above, the sites of the period are "independent", i.e. do not continue from Early Bronze Age. However, 38% of them continue into the second millennium BCE (the Middle Bronze Age II). All the rest are abandoned at the end of the period. Palumbo (1991, fig. 12) argues that 56% of the sites in the Jordan Valley have no continuation before and after, as well as 41% in

the "north of the central hill country".⁶

The typical site is small (1-2 dunams, or 0.25-0.5 acres, in area) and unfortified. Several large ones (Kh. Yusef [no. 117] and el-Bird [no. 91]) were undoubtedly used as central places. The existence of such centers was suggested in the Negev (Kochavi 1967; Cohen 1999, 83-299), a suggestion relevant also in our territory. Enclosure sites are rare, yet three enclosures seems to have been used for cult purposes. These are er-Rahweh (no. 7), el-'Aj-jam (no. 146) and es-Samrah (no. 129). Inside them no settlement remains were detected, and two are surrounded by standing monoliths. All three are situated in the vicinity of clusters of sites, so the connection between the latter and the enclosures is obvious.

Correlation of Middle Bronze Age I sites to water is low: about 15% (*i.e.*, only 15% of the sites are located up to 500 m from a perennial water source). This means that 85% were relatively far from water, a fact that drove the population to seek a solution for water storage. It is proposed here that this role was played by the large jars, a model similar to Iron Age I (Zertal 1986a).

Most sites are surrounded by grazing areas, so that correlation to

6 The data used by Palumbo do not contain most of the new sites, and his picture is unbalanced.

plains and flat ground is 70% (*i.e.*, there is no preference to hilly areas). On the same line, there is no preference for roads. Most of the sites are located in the fringes of valleys and other low ground.

The state of preservation of the period's sites is fair to good, like in the Negev hills. Our area can be looked at as a continuation of the "settlement strip" of this period – from North Sinai through the Negev and the Jordan Valley to Transjordan and Syria (Palumbo 1991, fig. 1). Each site has a theoretical territory of 11.5 sq. km. The shard scatter on the surface is fairly large.

In the Beth Shean Valley, Zori (1962, 197) found that 12% of the total number of sites belonged to the Middle Bronze Age I, a figure identical to ours. Gal (1980, 75) argues that the Issachar plateau became "a wandering area for the Middle Bronze Age I people". Most of the sites in his territory are tombs, and the population was "half nomads and sheep husbandries". However, in this territory six sites of the period were detected, a large number for this kind of economy and territory. Gal claims that "the plains and the plateaus were equal by settlement and economy." In Ephraim (Finkelstein 1988-1989, 139) only six settlement sites (to be separated from cemeteries) were recorded, mostly "in the Desert Fringes." This modest figure, within a territory identical to ours by size, must

stem from incomplete field work.

Our results support the view, shared by others, that Middle Bronze Age I is an intermediate age coming between two urban periods. This stands in contradiction to the opinions of Dever and others, who view the period as a continuation from Early Bronze Age III.

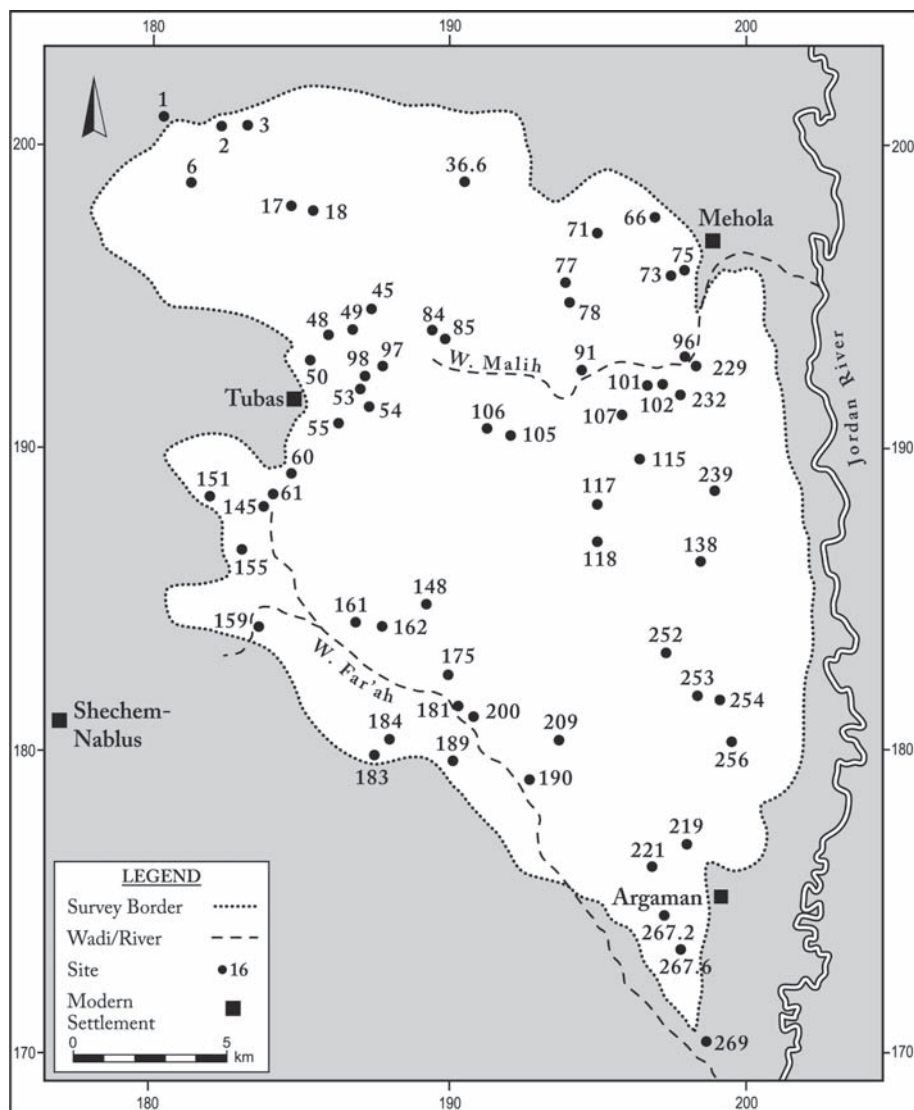
5. *Middle Bronze Age IIA-B*

The "settlement wave" of the second quarter of the second millennium BCE is well attested to in East Manasseh. Pottery of that period has been found in 63 sites, one third more than Middle Bronze Age I. Forty-three of them, or 72% of the total sites in vol. II, were founded upon virgin soil. This data again indicate new settlement considerations, relating to both the Mediterranean and the semi-arid, eastern territories (Kempinski 1992). In the neighboring area, the Shechem Syncline, there are 72 sites of the period upon an area smaller by 100 sq. km.

When the present research begun (Zertal 1988, 179) we were under the impression that East Manasseh was relatively empty in Middle Bronze Age II, an assumption that was soon negated. The population of the period settled in East Manasseh almost as much as in the Mediterranean zone, a fact indicating good adjustment to the semi-arid conditions. In East Manasseh itself, most

of the sites are concentrated in the fringes of the Eastern Valleys and the wadi valleys. There is a clustering of settlements, though less than in the preceding period. In the valleys of Zebabdeh and Tubas there are 15 sites; in Wadi Malih – nine; in the hills east of Ras Jadir – nine

and in Wadi Far'ah – ten sites. On the other hand, a landscape unit like the Buqe'ah (LU 17) and others are almost entirely unsettled. It seems that the differences between Middle Bronze Age I and Middle Bronze Age II are above all expressed by their economy: while



27. Map of the Middle Bronze Age IIA-B sites.

the former is based on sheep raising and a grazing economy, the latter is a combination of cereal growing and animal husbandry.

Assuming that the climate has remained unchanged, the population that settled in East Manasseh seems to be the outcome of a “population explosion” in the Mediterranean zone. This model repeats itself in Iron Age II, when people began to settle the fringes and semi-arid territories after complete cultivation of the better lands in the Mediterranean regions. Another section of the Middle Bronze Age II settlers may have originated in the Beth Shean area. However, these population movements should be examined in the future, after the accumulation of more data.

Most of the sites here are unfortified villages, 5-6 dunams (1.25-1.5 acres) in area. They differ from the Mediterranean zone to the west in the scarcity of sites here fortified by earthen ramps and fortified tells. The lack of rampart fortifications typical to the period precluded the creation of cone-shaped mounds, apart from a few sites (i.e. Kh. Yerzah A [no. 106], Tel Miski [no. 171] etc.). These few examples are small in area, and their foundation date is unclear. The only large tell is again Tel el-Far’ah, located on the “seam” between the Mediterranean and the semi arid zones.

In conclusion, the two characteristics of Mediterranean Canaan of

the period – the “city state” system based upon fortified tells and the political model of a “town with its daughters” – are both nonexistent in East Manasseh. This in itself may support the view of the east as a slightly later offshoot of the settlement nucleus in central Manasseh.

The first stage of the period, Middle Bronze Age IIA (ca. 2000-1750 BCE) is barely represented, a phenomenon similar in the Shechem Syncline (Zertal 2004, 51). Both stages were detected in the excavations of Tel el-Far’ah, yet the Middle Bronze Age IIA settlement was “poor and modest, when its people used the remains of the Early Bronze Age city wall for themselves” (De Vaux 1992, 1299). The city grew much in area and was enclosed by a new city wall only around 1700 BCE – Middle Bronze Age IIB. A similar history was recorded in Shechem, when the city was fortified (city wall D) during Middle Bronze Age IIB (Campbell 1993, 1349-1352). The ceramic inventory of Middle Bronze Age IIB is quite homogeneous, and the most typical vessel is the round and flat bowl with slightly folded rims. This was found also in almost all the survey sites.

In neighboring Beth Shean Valley, Zori (1962, 197) registered 43 sites of this period, including important tells like Beth Shean and *Rehob*. Gal (1980, 76-78) claims a settlement pattern similar to Manasseh in the

highlands of Issachar, yet much smaller in number. First, he argues, there were small, unfortified sites, with the later addition of the “city and daughters” model. In the Jezreel Valley and the Gilboa Hills, Zory (1977, 152) reports 40 sites of the period. Finkelstein (1988-1989, 142) reports about 14 sites in what he calls “fringes of the desert of Ephraim”. In our later work in these areas (Zertal forthcoming) this number has been more than doubled.

6. *Late Bronze Age I-II (= LBA I-II)*

This period shows a sharp decline in settlement, similar to the crisis all over hilly Palestine. Only nine sites continue to exist from Middle Bronze Age II, a decline of more than four fifths compared to its predecessor. The pattern of settlement is difficult to understand. The local pottery is rather hard to identify, and imported wares (most typical in excavations) are rarely found on the surface. In most of the sites (*e.g.*, Sheikh Safiriyan [no. 2], Kh. ed-Deir [no. 55], etc.) life continues from the Middle Bronze Age II period, but the population shrinks. This is also the situation in Tel el-Far‘ah (De Vaux 1992, 1300), whereas in the city of Shechem there is a relative prosperity, presumably due to the role played by Labayu and his capital in the el-Amarnah period (Naaman 1975;

Moran 1987).

There is no foundation of new sites on virgin soil. Apart from a few sites in Wadi Far‘ah, East Manasseh is almost uninhabited. In the Tubas Valley and Ras Jadir (LU 14, 16) only two sites continue from Middle Bronze Age II, while in Wadi Far‘ah there are five continuing sites.

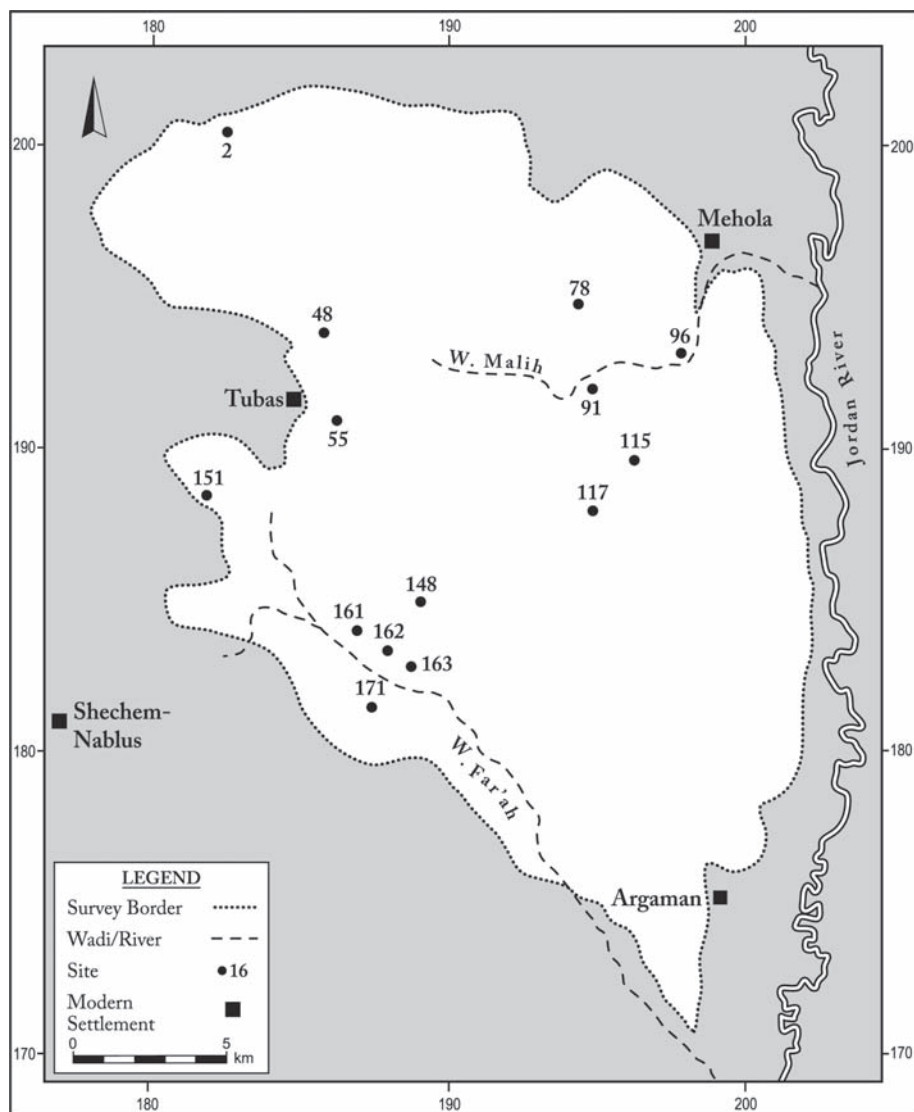
The lack of habitation is an important argument against the “nomadization theory”, based on the assumption that the same population became nomadic in the Late Bronze Age. During the survey a fair archaeological definition of the encampments, enclosures and other nomadic sites has been achieved, and none of these contained Late Bronze Age pottery.

A somewhat similar decline, though less acute, is registered in the Shechem Syncline: only 18 out of the 72 Middle Bronze Age II settlements continue into the Late Bronze Age (Zertal 2004, 53-54). It has already been suggested that the crisis took shape through the abandonment of the villages and unfortified sites and the entrance into the fortified tells, which were close to main roads and water sources. This process was most probably the outcome of the invasions by the Egyptian kings of the 18th dynasty (Weinstein 1975;1981).

The picture in the neighboring areas is similar to ours. In Ephraim,

Finkelstein (1988-1989, 110) defines "a severe crisis, one of the toughest in the history of the region", when only five sites remained in the whole territory. In the highlands of Issachar Gal (1980, 83) informs that "the number of sites

has much declined, and half of the unfortified settlements were deserted." In the Beth Shean Valley, Zori (1962, 197) registered 21 sites with Late Bronze Age pottery, a figure testifying to the relative stability there.



28. Map of the Late Bronze Age sites.

7. *Iron Age I (= IrA I, the period of the Israelite settlement and the Judges)*

Here the number of sites “jumps”, like in the Mediterranean zone. In 47 sites in East Manasseh, Iron Age I pottery has been found, four and a half times more than Late Bronze Age and 77% out of the total Middle Bronze Age II sites.

The material culture of Iron Age I is rather homogeneous. It coincides closely with the same culture in West Manasseh and that of the cultic center at Mt. Ebal. This is explained by the presumed unified ethnic origin of the Israelite tribes, although other ethnic groups may be represented as well.

Only a few of the sites (five) are located upon preceding Late Bronze Age places. The negative correlation between the two, together with the different material culture and the different settlement pattern, points toward a new ethnic group originating outside of the country. The Iron Age I sites are founded either upon virgin soil (44%) or upon sites abandoned in the end of Middle Bronze Age II. This again shows new considerations, different from both Middle Bronze Age II and Late Bronze Age.

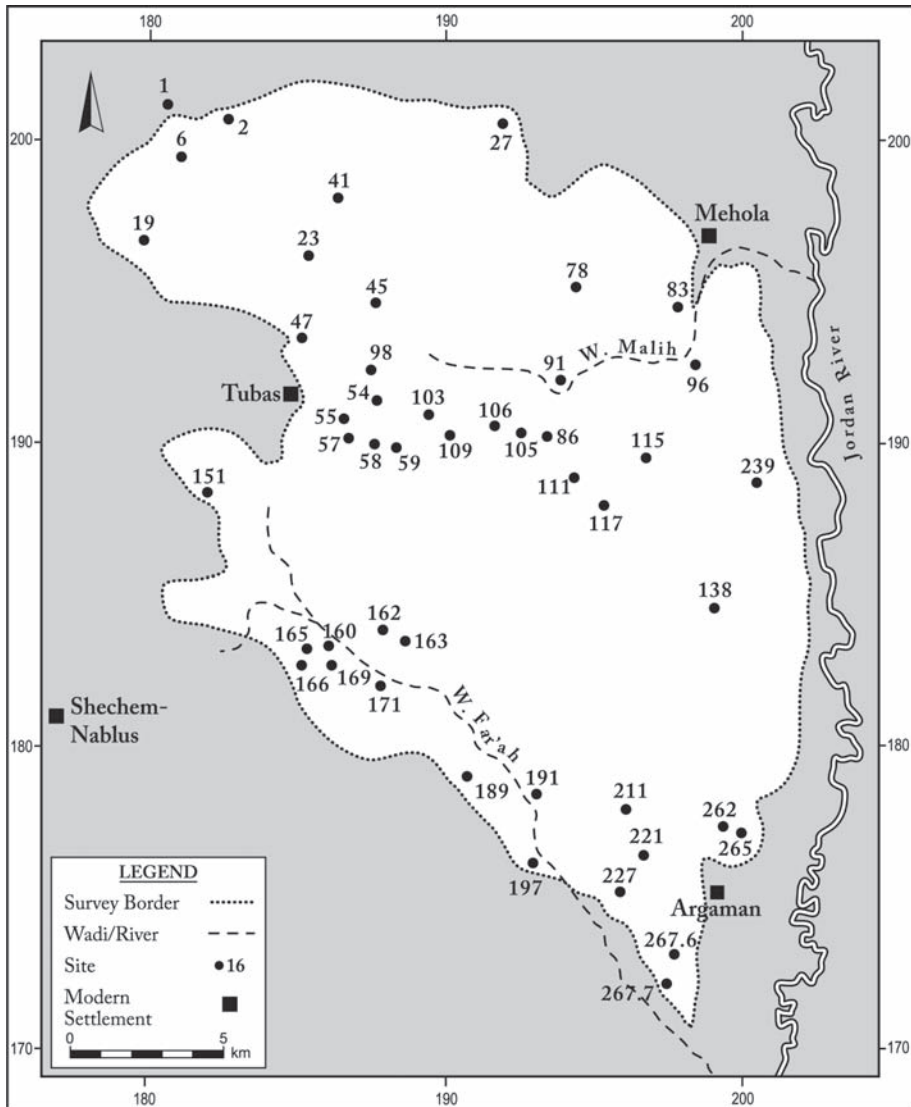
The typical Iron Age I site is small (1-4 dunams or 0.25-1.0 acre in area), with few buildings; most contain a cluster of houses (small village – Stager 1981). Architectur-

ally they may be divided into three categories: those that continued and later became the basis for an Iron Age II fortified tell; those that were preserved with their original plan and those where only a pottery scatter survived (*e.g.*, Ras Jadir [no. 103], Khallet en-Nakhleh [no. 109], *etc.*). In 73% of the total (34 sites), which continued into Iron Age II, the original plan is blurred or unknown. On the other hand, the well preserved sites (mostly in remote areas) are almost always enclosures dating to the early part of the period (13th -12th centuries BCE). These are, for example, the sites at Khallet Makhul (no. 136), Wadi Abd el-'Al [no. 211], 'Iraq Matar [no. 265], *etc.* The latter can be used as a typical example: a round circle of large stones is built close to a low cliff, with foundations of simple houses outside the circle. The pottery includes the typical vessels, mainly jugs and cooking pots.

A special, remarkable kind of sites are the large enclosures, exemplified by el-'Unuq (no. 160). This “shoe shaped” enclosure located near Wadi Far'ah is 14 dunams (3.5 acres) in area. It is enclosed by a low stone wall and divided by a low wall into two areas, one twice the size of the other. Several walls inside indicate possible inner architecture. Most of the potsherds (*ca.* 90%) belong to the Iron Age Iron Age and the “Eynun family”.

The phenomenon of the large enclosures, three of which are in the Jordan Valley (*cf.* Zertal 2005, sites 65, 92 and 105), and two of them already excavated, was interpreted as the biblical *gilgal*, a kind of sites not found archaeologically until now (Zertal 1991; 1998).

The Iron Age I sites are arranged in three main strips: Wadi Far'ah (13 sites), Wadi Malih (12 sites) and the eastern valleys (ten sites), with an additional group in the Tubas Valley. These strips may be interpreted prudently as the "lines of entrance" of the new populace.



29. Map of the Iron Age I sites.

Here chronological research should be involved: is there a chronological difference between the Mediterranean zone of Manasseh and the east? Unlike the Middle Bronze Age II sites, where the east is later than the Mediterranean settlements and began as an offshoot of them, in the Iron Age the eastern area seems to have preceded – during Iron Age I – the western one by at least one chronological stage. This conclusion is based upon the development of the three types of cooking pots, A-C. It has already been shown (Zertal 1988, 295-297; 1991) that the earliest cooking pot type A (14th-13th centuries BCE) is more widespread in the east, and the further the sites are located westwards, the later is the type of cooking pot. The logic explanation to this phenomenon is the slow, gradual movement of the settling elements from the east (Jordan Valley) to the west.

It has been proposed (Zertal 2000, 400-425) that elements of the “proto tribes”, *i.e.*, families that later organized as tribes (Manasseh-Machir, Ephraim, Judah, Levi, Issachar, Asher, *etc.*), were crystallized in the Manassite allotment. They all are mentioned in different contexts within this territory, and only then the settlement continued to the coast (where the “Sea Peoples” were already settling) and north (the Jezreel Valley).

Our work, which has continued

since the publication of the Hebrew volume (1996), above all in the Jordan Valley, seems to fully support these finds.

8. *Iron Age II (= IrA II, the northern kingdom of Israel)*

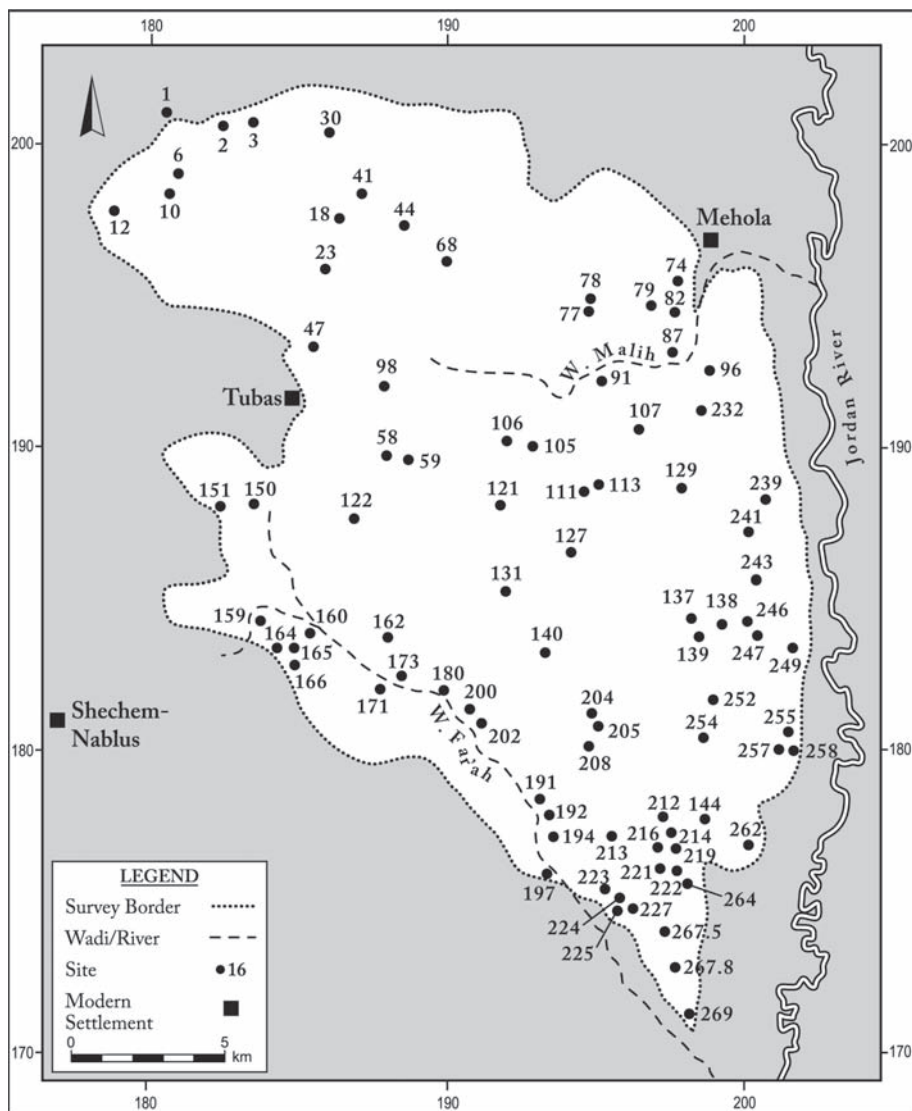
This is one of the settlement peaks in terms of number of sites. No fewer than 86 sites yielded Iron Age II pottery – twice as many as Iron Age I and one third more than Middle Bronze Age II. About half of these were newly founded on virgin soil, and the question arises for the reasons for such a “population explosion”.

Iron Age II encompasses a wide variety of site types, from encampments to fortified cities and tells. Twenty of the sites (23% of the total) are multi period tells, most of which were founded in that period; one quarter of the total are villages 2 to 10 dunams (0.5-2.5 acres) in area and the rest are small places: farmsteads, encampments and roadside fortresses. These small sites strongly typify East Manasseh in general.

Most of the fortified tells (the *Ir Mivtzar* of the Bible) are located in the eastern valleys and along Wadi Far‘ah. Kh. Fuqahah (no. 47) and Kh. ‘Eynun (no. 58), both in the fringes of Tubas Valley, are examples of this type. These typical mounds are built upon a natural hill and are enclosed by a stone-built city wall

(unlike the “Hyksosite” Middle Bronze Age II tells, based upon earth ramparts). In many cases, the wall remains are still seen today. On the summit and the slopes there are also remains of buildings. There is a close correlation between the location of each tell and its elevation,

view from the place, and nearby roads. The proximity to roads (more than 80% of the tells are less than 500 m away from roads of type B) suggests that the sites were developed in accordance to the region as a passage area (from Transjordan to the heartland of the kingdom). Wa-



30. Map of the Iron Age II sites.

ter proximity was a secondary element in choosing the site's location, because water storage in cisterns was already developed and perennial sources of water had lost some of their importance.

Around the cities, the villages (called "town" – *Ir* in the bible, and *cf.* already Stager 1981) are scattered. Kh. Salhab (no. 23), for example, is located in the southern fringes of Zebabdeh Valley. It is a small site with crowded buildings lacking any defensive characteristics. It has only a loose correlation with view and elevation, and it relates above all to the cultivable plain around it and to road B7.

The third section, small sites, offers evidence of population growth and the "coverage" of all kinds of lands and topography. Farms could utilize small patches of cultivable land and pasture land. The small sites are evidence of the relatively good security conditions of the Kingdom of Samaria, which was able to defend its periphery against enemies and marauding nomads.

However, taking into account the invasions into East Manasseh of the Ammonites and Aramaeans from the 9th century BCE and on, this high level of security is somewhat surprising.

Most of the farms have a "classical" shape of the semi-arid zone: a central house, a courtyard and secondary buildings for animals.

The courtyard, which comprises 80% or more of the sites' area, indicates the dual economy – animal husbandry and cereal growing. The average rainfall was enough to grow barley and wheat upon 10 to 50 dunams (2.5-12.5 acres) per site in the Buqe'ah. Pasturage (green in wintertime and dry in the summer) again sufficed for a small herd of sheep and goats. An example of a farm is Abu Sha'areh (no. 246) located upon a wide hilltop, between the Buqe'ah and the Desert Fringes. It has a main building (now covered), a large oval courtyard, a gate construction and a small outer buildings.

The roadside fortresses defended the roads. From the 9th century BCE onward, the round towers of the "Malfuf" type emerged as the main type (Zertal 1995), replacing the casemate fort of the end of Iron Age I (*cf.* Muntar esh-Shaqq – no. 83). Nevertheless, the casemate fort continued to be used in some cases (Ras Hamud, no. 91).

Despite the variety of the landscape units in the area, there is a pattern in the Iron Age II site scatter. Most of them are concentrated in the Landscape Units of Wadi Far'ah, the Desert Fringes, Ras Humsah, the Buqe'ah and east Wadi Malih. Ras es-Salmeh is almost empty, and the valleys of Zebabdeh and Tubas are sparsely settled, presumably for the existence of many tells there. Crowded groups of sites are also